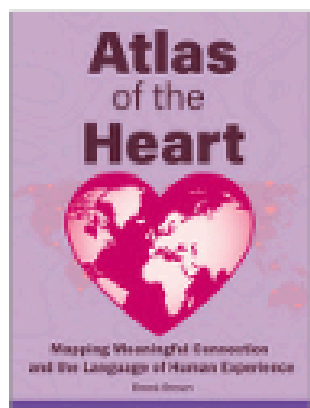




ATLAS OF THE HEART

Mapping Meaningful Connection and the
Language of Human Experience

Brené Brown



The Big “So What”

Do you sometimes feel misunderstood or struggle to explain how you feel? *Atlas of the Heart* equips you with the emotional language to understand and communicate how you feel, build stronger relationships, and navigate life experiences with greater clarity.



Introduction: Mapping the Human Experience



Language helps us make sense of and navigate life experiences; it affects our decisions, behaviors, and relationships. By naming our emotions, we gain clarity on what we feel and why, facilitating emotion regulation and psychosocial well-being.



In this book, Brené Brown maps out 87 human emotions and experiences (or thoughts that lead to emotions) to help us identify, understand, and talk about the feelings that shape our lives.

- It categorizes emotions into 13 “places” we go when we experience life situations. By thinking of our emotions and experiences as places, we can consider questions like: Where am I? How did I get here? How do I move to where I want to be?
- Brown's insights are based on more than 20 years of studying emotions, vulnerability, and human connection. This includes an extensive review of over 1,500 academic publications, and analyzing thousands of stories and experiences.

KEY QUOTES

“I want this book to be an atlas for all of us, because I believe that with an adventurous heart and the right maps, we can travel anywhere and never fear losing ourselves. Even when we don’t know where we are.”

“Language is our portal to meaning-making, connection, healing, learning, and self-awareness. Having access to the right words can open up entire universes.”

“Naming an experience doesn’t give the experience more power, it gives us the power of understanding and meaning.”



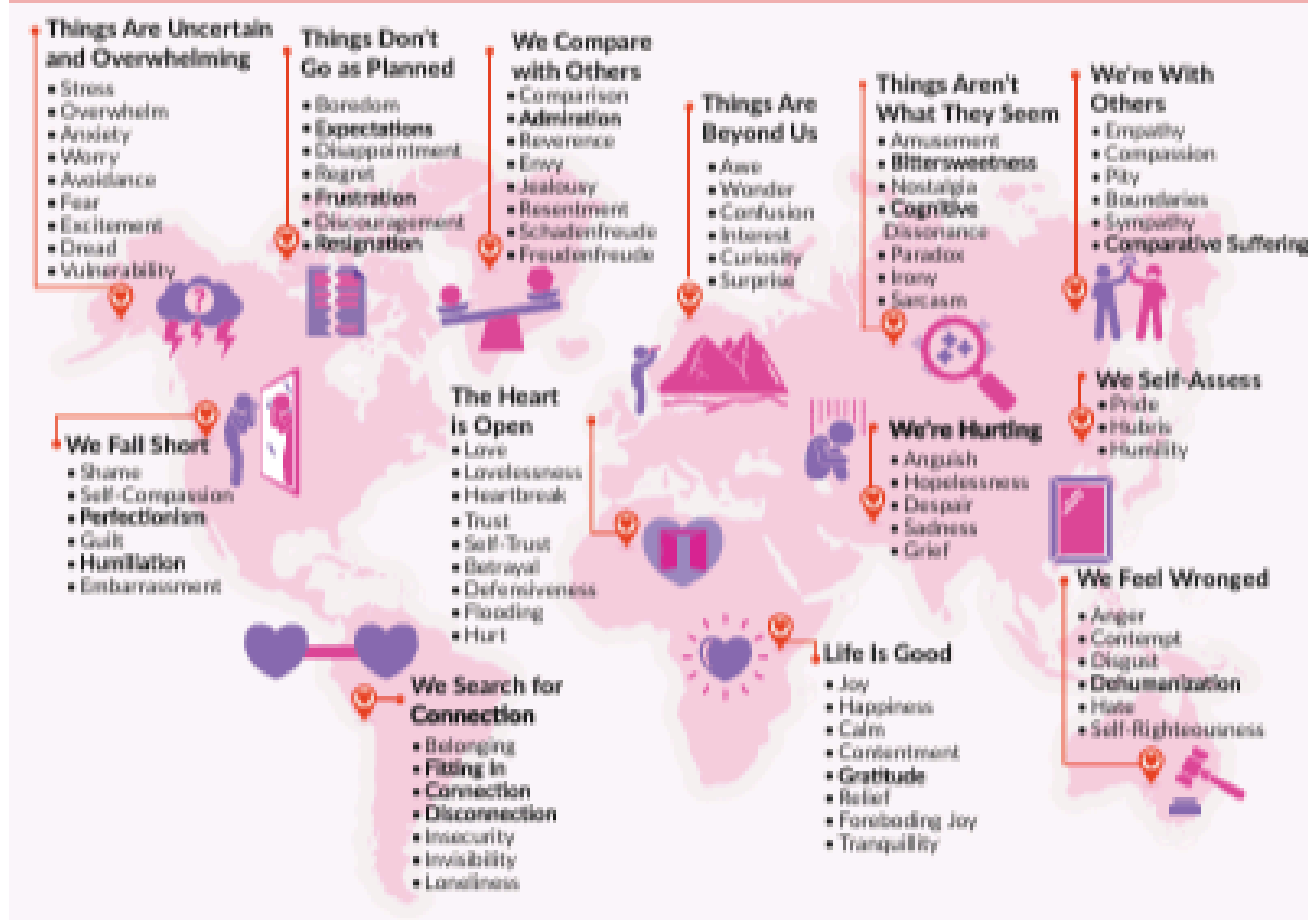
Mapping out the 87 Emotions



As you explore each “place” on the atlas, consider how emotions manifest in your life in 4 ways:

- Biology: How emotions physically manifest in your body;
- Biography: How your family, upbringing, and culture shape your emotional responses;
- Behavior: The habitual ways you react to emotions; and
- Backstory: The triggers or contexts that lead to these emotions.

Places We Go Emotionally When...



1. Places We Go When Things Are Uncertain or Overwhelming



Stress is the feeling of being overburdened by external demands. It's linked to a sense of uncertainty and lack of control. It triggers physical, mental, and emotional responses in our body, such as increased heart rate and cortisol production.

- The level of stress is determined more by our perception of how well we're coping, rather than the actual demands.

KEY QUOTES

"Human emotions and experiences are layers of biology, biography, behavior, and backstory."

"Without understanding how our feelings, thoughts, and behaviors work together, it's almost impossible to find our way back to ourselves and each other."

"Feeling stressed and feeling overwhelmed seem to be related to our perception of how we are coping with our current situation and our ability to handle the accompanying emotions."

 A buildup of stress leads to overwhelm, where we feel paralyzed because there's too much happening at once. We lose mental clarity and tend to make poor decisions.

- Stress feels like you're struggling with your tasks, while overwhelm feels like you're drowning and unable to function.
- The best solution is to take a break—to engage in play or do nothing—to recover and reset your mental state.

 Anxiety involves tension, worry, and a growing sense of uncertainty and loss of control. We tend to dwell on worst-case scenarios, which amplifies the sense of helplessness. It also manifests physically through increased heart rate, muscle tension, restlessness, etc.

- Anxiety can be a temporary response (state), or it can be a more permanent part of your personality (trait). People with persistent or chronic anxiety might require professional support.

 Worry and avoidance are 2 ineffective ways of coping with anxiety:

- Worrying or repeatedly thinking about negative possibilities wastes mental energy and reinforces anxiety.
- Avoidance or dodging the causes of anxiety might offer relief in the moment, but increases anxiety in the long run.

 It's more effective to reframe anxious feelings as excitement. Both feelings bring similar physical sensations like increased heart rate and energy. By relabeling your feelings—telling yourself you're excited, not anxious—you can positively shift your perception of the experience.

 Dread and fear are closely associated with anxiety.

- Dread is a form of anxiety that arises when you anticipate something negative that feels inevitable. It intensifies as the event draws nearer (e.g. a big presentation or a medical procedure), and you might just want to "get it over with." Acknowledge the dread to prepare yourself mentally, but don't focus on it as it could lead to mental exhaustion.
- Fear is an instinctive response to an immediate threat, unlike anxiety which is future-oriented. It's a protective mechanism

KEY QUOTES

"Stressed is being in the weeds. Overwhelmed is being blown."

"Anxiety feels like...escalating loss of control, worst-case scenario thinking and imagery, and total uncertainty."

"Our anxiety often leads to one of two coping mechanisms: worry or avoidance. Unfortunately, neither of these coping strategies is very effective."

"Anxiety and excitement feel the same, but how we interpret and label them can determine how we experience them."

"If we can't handle uncertainty, risk, and emotional exposure in a way that aligns with our values and furthers our organizational goals, we can't lead."

to prepare us for danger. We can learn to distinguish between true danger and irrational fears (e.g. fear of social rejection).



Vulnerability is an emotion experienced during times of uncertainty, risk, or emotional exposure. It's not about "letting your guard down" or exposing yourself unnecessarily. It's about engaging wholeheartedly even if you can't control the outcome.

- It is not a sign of weakness but an indicator of courage.



2. Places We Go When We Compare With Others



Comparison is a cognitive process that leads to various feelings. It often happens unconsciously, making it hard to recognize its impact on our behaviors and relationships.

- Comparison is about trying to fit in and stand out at the same time. You want to belong, yet you want to be superior to others.
- Both upward and downward comparisons can trigger negative emotions like anger, fear, shame, and sadness.
 - (i) When you compare yourself *upward* to someone who seems better off, you may feel inferior, insecure, or inspired.
 - (ii) When you compare yourself *downward* to someone who seems less successful or fortunate, you may feel temporarily superior, but it erodes long-term satisfaction.
- Choose to refocus on your own path instead, e.g. focus on your personal progress instead of comparing with others during a task or competition.



Comparison might bring admiration and reverence:

- Admiration arises when others' abilities, accomplishments, or characteristics inspire us to become better versions of ourselves. It's not about wanting to be that person, but feeling motivated to improve ourselves.
- Reverence is a deeper form of admiration, often linked to a sense of awe. It's about aligning yourself with the qualities you value, and it's usually associated with things/experiences that feel sacred or transcendent, such as religion, nature, or art.

KEY QUOTES

"Vulnerability is not weakness; it's our greatest measure of courage."

"Comparison is the crush of conformity from one side and competition from the other—it's trying to simultaneously fit in and stand out."

"Comparison says, 'Be like everyone else, but better!'"

"We can choose connection over comparison."

"While admiration fosters selfbetterment, reverence seems to foster a desire for connection to what we revere—we want to move closer to that thing or person."



Comparison can also cause envy or jealousy.

- Envy is about wanting something that someone else possesses, be it *attraction* (appearance or social popularity), *competence* (intelligence, skills, or expertise) or *wealth* (material possessions, financial status, or lifestyle).
 - Envy could be *hostile* (you want what they have and hope they will lose it), or *non-hostile* (you desire what they have without wishing them harm).
 - Acknowledge your feelings of envy and don't allow it to dominate your thoughts and relationships.
- Jealousy is the fear of losing something you possess and value to someone else. It usually involves 3 parties in relationships—be it romantic relationships, friendships, or family. For example, you might fear losing your partner's affection to a rival.
 - Some jealousy is normal. But if left unchecked, it can lead to destructive behaviors like possessiveness or aggression.



Resentment involves a mix of frustration, judgment, anger, and envy.

- It's often mistaken for anger, but it actually stems from envy. You feel resentful not because of others' behaviors, but because you wish you could do/have the same things.
- To manage resentment, address the root causes, such as:
 - (i) Unmet needs, e.g. feeling overburdened or unappreciated because you failed to set boundaries with yourself/others.
 - (ii) Perfectionism, e.g. resenting that others can take it easy or accept lower standards.
 - (iii) Unvoiced or unrealistic expectations that set you up for disappointment.



Schadenfreude is about deriving pleasure from another person's misfortune or suffering.

- It's often driven by insecurity, inferiority, or fear arising from:
 - (i) Social comparison: when we see others' failure as a relief or a boost to our own self-esteem; or

KEY QUOTES

"Envy occurs when we want something that another person has. Jealousy is when we fear losing a relationship or a valued part of a relationship that we already have."

"We think jealousy in response to how we feel."

"While resentment is definitely an emotion, I normally recognize it by a familiar thought pattern: What mean and critical thing am I rehearsing saying to this person?"

"Your lack of work is not making me resentful, my lack of rest is making me resentful."

"Nothing that celebrates the humiliation or pain of another person builds lasting connection."

(ii) Groupthink and collective schadenfreude, especially when the suffering person is a rival or part of an opposing group.

- Schadenfreude can feel good in the moment and create a temporary sense of group bonding. But in the long run, it erodes values like empathy or kindness, creates guilt, shame, and other negative social dynamics.



Freudenfreude is the pleasure or joy we feel in response to another person's success or happiness. It's the opposite of schadenfreude, reflecting our ability to empathize and share in others' positive emotions.

- It deepens relationships and builds emotional resilience by promoting positive social interactions and a sense of community.
- Here are 2 ways to practice freudenfreude:
 - (i) *Shoy*: Intentionally share in the joy of someone's success by showing interest and asking follow-up questions; and
 - (ii) *Bragitude*: Expressing gratitude to those who celebrate your success.



3. Places We Go When Things Don't Go as Planned



Boredom often arises from a lack of stimulation, or when tasks feel repetitive and without purpose.

- How we feel when bored depends on our levels of autonomy or control. When we have little control over a boring task, we tend to feel irritated or frustrated. If we have control over the task, we might feel lethargic or disinterested.
- Boredom is actually essential for creativity. When we're bored, our minds tend to wander, fueling creativity and problem-solving.



Disappointment occurs when things don't turn out as we expected. The higher the expectation, the greater the disappointment.

- Often, disappointments arise from silent expectations that we haven't communicated or even acknowledged to ourselves.

KEY QUOTES

"If this is your flame and the wind picks up, good friends cup their hands around your flame to prevent it from going out. And you do the same for them."

"The lack of stimulation that defines 'being bored' gives our imagination room to play and grow."

*"Boredom is your imagination calling to you."
—Sherry Turkle*

"Disappointment is unmet expectations. The more significant the expectations, the more significant the disappointment."

These set us up for frustration, especially if they involve outcomes beyond our control (e.g. how others react or respond).

- Some people try to avoid disappointment by reducing their expectations and adopting a cynical view of life. They end up numbing their emotions and feeling unfulfilled.
- The best way to manage disappointment is by reality-checking our expectations and communicating them clearly. We will still get disappointed, but it's easier to navigate the experience when there's a shared understanding of what went wrong.



Regret occurs when we don't get the outcomes we wanted or hoped for, and wish we had made different choices.

- Unlike disappointment, which is often about events outside our control, regret involves personal responsibility. In the short term, we tend to regret actions that led to undesirable outcomes. But in the long term, we tend to regret the actions we didn't take and their missed opportunities.
- Regret can be a powerful teacher. Analyze your regrets to gain wisdom and make more courageous decisions in the future. Practice self-compassion to take accountability in a healthy way.



Discouragement is the loss of confidence or motivation, usually after repeated failures, persistent lack of progress, or unmet expectations. However, you might still take action.



Resignation is the sense of futility that no matter what you do, things won't improve. You lose hope and stop trying.



Frustration is the feeling that arises when your goals are obstructed. It overlaps with anger, but with a key difference—With anger, you feel you can still do something to fix the situation; with frustration it feels like there's nothing you can do.



4. Places We Go When Things Are Beyond Us



Awe is the feeling from encountering something so vast or unfamiliar—be it nature, art, or a powerful idea—that it challenges our understanding of the world. It's more passive in nature, leading us to observe the phenomenon in amazement.

KEY QUOTES

"There are too many people in the world today who decide to live disappointed rather than risk feeling disappointment."

"Communicating our expectations is brave and vulnerable."

"If you have no regrets, or you intentionally set out to live without regrets, I think you're missing the power of regret to teach us."

"Regrets about not taking chances have made me braver. Regrets about shaming or blaming people I care about have made me more thoughtful."

"When feeling awe, we tend to simply stand back and observe...Wonder fuels our passion for exploration and learning, for curiosity and adventure."



Wonder, on the other hand, sparks our curiosity and amazement. It energizes us and inspires us actively explore, ask questions, and learn/understand more.



Confusion occurs when we face something we can't understand or information that conflicts with what we know.

- It's an uncomfortable feeling that makes us question what we know, and it's essential for learning and growth. "Optimal confusion" helps us to seek out answers, solve problems, and learn more deeply.



Curiosity is the desire to learn, explore, or close a knowledge gap.

- It can be both a trait (e.g. being naturally curious) and a state (e.g. being curious about something specific). It drives us to actively question, investigate, and discover, unlike interest which is more passive.



Interest is more of a cognitive state, when you're focused and open to something that's appealing, relevant, or engaging. You can be interested but not curious; but you can't be curious without being first interested.



Surprise occurs when something unexpected interrupts our mental flow and makes us reevaluate the situation.

- Surprise serves as a bridge between our thought and feelings. It's a fleeting emotion that fades within seconds, once the rational brain processes the situation.
- It also amplifies emotion: the more unexpected the event, the stronger the emotional response afterward. That's why surprising news is more likely to be shared and surprising messages more likely to get noticed.



5. Places We Go When Things Aren't What They Seem



Amusement is a light, playful emotion typically triggered by humor or unexpected situations.

- It's usually brief, providing a momentary relief from stress, and creating social bonds through a sense of humor, playfulness, and camaraderie.

KEY QUOTES

"Confusion, like many uncomfortable things in life, is vital for learning."

"We have to have some level of knowledge or awareness before we can become curious. We aren't curious about something we are unaware of or know nothing about."

"With interest, our mind is open to seeing what's there, but with curiosity, we've acknowledged a gap in what we know or understand, and our heart and head are both invested in closing that gap."

"We can think of surprise as 'a bridge between cognition and emotion.' But it's a short bridge!"



Bittersweetness is the mixed feeling of happiness and sadness at the same time. It involves joy from what is, combined with sadness at the impermanence of that joy, e.g. watching your children grow up.

- Bittersweetness is different from ambivalence which involves uncertainty or indecision about feelings.



Nostalgia is a bittersweet feeling of remembering the past, with both happiness for those memories and sadness for the loss of those times.

- It involves yearning for the way things used to be, and seeing the past in a way that feels better than they really were. It's a double-edged sword, since it can offer a sense of continuity and social connection, but can also be a way to escape current realities by dwelling on the past.



Cognitive dissonance occurs when we hold two conflicting beliefs or ideas simultaneously.

- This is uncomfortable, so we try to resolve the contradiction in some way—often by rejecting conflicting information, downplaying their importance, justifying our actions, or changing our beliefs/actions. For example, smokers who know smoking is harmful but continue to smoke might convince themselves that smoking relaxes them, or the risks are exaggerated.
- Don't rush to resolve the discomfort from dissonance. Remain curious to uncover deeper insights and growth.



Paradox refers to the coexistence of two seemingly contradictory truths. For example, leaders must be both assertive and empathetic to succeed. Or, we admire vulnerability in others yet we resist showing it ourselves.

- Cognitive dissonance demands resolution, whereas paradox asks that we accept and live with the tension between opposites. In the process, we uncover deeper truths about ourselves and the world.



Irony and sarcasm are both ways of saying one thing and meaning something else.

- Irony occurs when the surface/literal meaning of our words and actions contradicts the intended meaning, e.g. saying

KEY QUOTES

"Multiple emotions, such as happiness and sadness, may be rapidly vacillating below our consciousness, but our interpretation may be a more integrated emotional experience."

"Nostalgia can be a part of both healthy and unhealthy coping strategies, depending on an individual's personality and coping style."

"It's brave to invite new information to the table, to sit with it and hear it out. It's also rare these days."

"If we're willing to stay with it and stay curious, complexity is one of our greatest teachers."

"Embracing the paradox teaches us how to think deeper and with more complexity...It moves us away from oversimplifying how systems, organizations, and humans work."

"The same way you feel a muscle 'burn' when it's being strengthened, the brain needs to feel some discomfort when it's learning."

"What a beautiful day!" during a rainstorm. It tends to be more subtle, relying on the audience to grasp the contradiction.

- Sarcasm is a type of irony where the words are intended to mock, ridicule, or criticize someone. It tends to have a sharp or biting tone to express frustration or disapproval.
- Both irony and sarcasm should be used with care, as they're often misunderstood, especially when communicating with someone unfamiliar, during emotionally-charged situations, or in text-based communication. Be mindful of using sarcasm around children, as they usually can't grasp the intended meaning until they're 9-10 years old.



6. Places We Go When We're Hurting



Anguish is an overwhelming mix of shock, grief, incredulity, and powerlessness. These feelings jointly cause so much physical and emotional pain that they can literally bring us to our knees, causing us to collapse in on ourselves.

- Anguish is often experienced in moments of deep trauma or unbearable loss. The sense of powerlessness makes it especially traumatic, since we cannot reverse or change what has happened. It takes time and support to gradually recover the pieces of ourselves and re-engage with life again.



Hopelessness is the feeling that things won't improve no matter what you do. You're unable to set realistic goals or find a way to improve the situation.

- It usually arises from negative life events and thought patterns, e.g. self-blame or feeling powerless to influence certain outcomes in a job or relationship.
- Prolonged hopelessness often leads to depression and suicidal thoughts. To cultivate hope: set realistic goals, find flexible options to achieve those goals, build belief in ourselves, and seek help and support.



Despair is a deeper and wider sense of hopelessness that affects one's entire outlook on life. It leads to the sense that you're trapped in the current suffering with no way out.

KEY QUOTES

"Are you dressing something up in humor that actually requires clarity and honesty?"

"Anguish often causes us to physically crumble in on ourselves, literally bringing us to our knees or forcing us all the way to the ground."

"The human spirit is resilient, and just as we can reclaim our ability to breathe and feel and think, we can rebuild the bones that anguish rips away. But it takes help and time."

"We need hope like we need air. To live without hope is to risk suffocating on hopelessness and despair, risk being crushed by the belief that there is no way out of what is holding us back, no way to get to what we desperately need."

- Use Martin Seligman's 3Ps to build resilience and manage despair:

- (i) *Personalization*: Don't blame yourself when things go wrong; recognize that external factors also play a big role.
- (ii) *Permanence*: Remind yourself that setbacks and challenges are temporary.
- (iii) *Pervasiveness*: When something seems to be ruining your whole life, remember that other good things still exist.



Sadness is a natural emotional response to loss, defeat, or disappointment.

- It's unpleasant, but allows us to process difficult experiences. Studies show that sadness can improve focus, make us more resistant to judgment errors, increase generosity or acts of kindness, and improve human connection.
- Unlike clinical depression, sadness is typically short-term and situational. Acknowledging sadness is an important step in cultivating self-compassion and empathy for others.



Grief is a complex process that involves many emotions, such as sadness, anger, longing, and guilt.

- Brown's research uncovered 3 core aspects of grief:
 - (i) *Loss*: It includes tangible losses (e.g. death or separation) and intangible losses (e.g. loss of normalcy or security).
 - (ii) *Longing*: It involves a deep yearning for what was lost, whether it's a person, a way of life, or a significant event.
 - (iii) *Feeling lost*: It requires us to adapt emotionally, physically, and socially, which can be disorienting.
- Recent research found that people experience grief differently—in different stages with no fixed progression or timeline.
 - (i) People who're grieving don't necessarily need solutions. They need others to be present, to acknowledge their loss, and to have time/space to process things at their own pace.
 - (ii) Storytelling and connection aid healing, as they allow grief to be shared and validated as we process our loss.

KEY QUOTES

"When extreme hopelessness seeps into all the corners of our lives and combines with extreme sadness, we feel despair."

"Hope is a function of struggle—we develop hope not during the easy or comfortable times, but through adversity and discomfort."

"To be human is to know sadness. Owning our sadness is courageous and a necessary step in finding our way back to ourselves and each other."

"The more difficult it is for us to articulate our experiences of loss, longing, and feeling lost to the people around us, the more disconnected and alone we feel."

"Grief does not obey your plans, or your wishes. Grief will do whatever it wants to you, whenever it wants to. In that regard, Grief has a lot in common with Love."
— Elizabeth Gilbert

- (iii) Grief may never fully go away, but we can still move forward while honoring what has been lost.



7. Places We Go with Others



Compassion is about consistently treating ourselves and others with kindness, recognizing suffering in others and taking action to support those in pain.

- True compassion is grounded in equality. It's not about "fixing" others, but being present with them, facing the discomfort together, and offering companionship and support.
- Compassion vs empathy. Empathy is a key skill/tool of compassion. It focuses on understanding and sharing in another's emotions, while compassion goes further to care for others with a healthy boundary.



Empathy is the ability to understand and share in others' feelings. It helps people to feel heard, understood, and less alone in their experiences.

- Empathy allows us to understand and validate others' emotions, without necessarily taking them on ourselves.
- There are 2 types of empathy. Brown emphasizes the importance of cognitive empathy for true connection and compassion.
 - (i) Cognitive empathy: Understanding others' thoughts and feelings without necessarily sharing in their emotional state.
 - (ii) Affective empathy: Feeling what the other person is feeling. This can be emotionally taxing and may lead to overwhelm.



Sympathy involves feeling sorry for someone, but from a distance. It often reinforces a sense of separation rather than connection, and can trigger feelings of shame and isolation in the other person.



Pity involves feeling sorry for someone else's misfortune.

- It creates distance and makes the person being pitied feel alienated or diminished, because it's about:

KEY QUOTES

"Compassion is the daily practice of recognizing and accepting our shared humanity so that we treat ourselves and others with loving-kindness, and we take action in the face of suffering."

"Only when we know our own darkness well can we be present with the darkness of others."
—Pema Chödrön

"I believe meaningful connection requires a combination of compassion and cognitive empathy or perspective taking."

"We can respond empathically only if we are willing to be present to someone's pain. If we're not willing to do that, it's not real empathy."

"There's nothing worse than feeling pitied."

- (i) Seeing others as inferior because of their suffering;
- (ii) Feeling sorry for them without actively helping;
- (iii) Keeping your emotional distance; and
- (iv) Avoiding sharing their pain ("I'm glad I'm not in your shoes").



Boundaries define acceptable behavior and emotional limits. They are essential for healthy relationships because they establish where one person ends and another begins.

- Clear boundaries allow for autonomy, respect, and compassion while protecting your emotional health. Without boundaries, relationships can become enmeshed, with one person losing their sense of self or taking on too much responsibility for the other's emotions.



Comparative suffering occurs when we compare our pain to others', on the belief that if someone else suffers more, then our own suffering is less valid.

- This falsely assumes that love, care and concern are limited resources. In reality, the more you practice empathy or compassion, the more it expands.



8. Places We Go When We Fall Short



Shame is the "intensely painful feeling or experience of believing that we are flawed and therefore unworthy of love, belonging, and connection."

- To counter shame, we need self-compassion and empathy:
 - (i) Self-compassion (which includes self-kindness, common humanity, and mindfulness) helps us to acknowledge our humanity and to be gentle with ourselves and our missteps.
 - (ii) Empathy reminds us that we're not alone, reduces the power of shame, and opens the door to healing.
- Everyone experiences shame. We're afraid to talk about it, yet the less we talk about it the more control it has over us. To build shame resilience:

KEY QUOTES

"If there's no autonomy between people, then there's no compassion or empathy, just enmeshment."

"Empathy is not finite, and compassion is not a pizza with eight slices. When you practice empathy and compassion with someone, there is not less of these qualities to go around. There's more."

"Where shame exists, empathy is almost always absent. That's what makes shame dangerous. The opposite of experiencing shame is experiencing empathy."

- (i) Recognize shame and its triggers;
- (ii) Question if the shame triggers are realistic or fair;
- (iii) Share your experiences with those you trust for support; and
- (iv) Speak shame openly and ask for what you need.



Shame is different from guilt or humiliation.

- Shame is targeted at the self—the feeling that “I am bad” or “I am unworthy.”
- Guilt arises when we recognize that our behavior or actions have gone against our values or caused harm to others. It's targeted at actions—the feeling that “I did something bad.” If handled constructively, it can motivate positive change.
- Humiliation occurs when we feel we've been unfairly devalued by others. Unlike shame, we don't internalize it as a reflection of our self-worth. But when people are humiliated—especially in ways that target their identity—they might feel intense anger/rejection, leading to aggression or violence.



Embarrassment is a mild, often fleeting emotional response to feeling self-conscious, exposed, or awkward in front of others, e.g. doing something clumsy or making a mistake in public. Unlike shame or humiliation, embarrassment is usually temporary and harmless.



Perfectionism is the belief that we can shield ourselves from feelings of shame, judgment, or blame, by doing things perfectly (or presenting ourselves as flawless).

- It's driven by the fear of failure and rejection, rather than a genuine desire for excellence. It blocks personal growth and success by focusing on earning approval and avoiding criticism. In trying to meet impossible standards and gain external validation, we feel inadequate, burned out, or stuck in a cycle of inaction.
- By contrast, healthy striving focuses on growth and progress. It embraces mistakes and failures as part of the learning process.

KEY QUOTES

“The antidote to shame is empathy. If we reach out and share our shame experience with someone who responds with empathy, shame dissipates.”

“Where perfectionism exists, shame is always lurking.”

“Perfectionism is externally driven by a simple but potentially all-consuming question: What will people think?”



9. Places We Go When We Search for Connection



Belonging is the deep, visceral feeling that you are accepted and valued for who you truly are. It is a core human need, essential for emotional and psychological well-being.

- Unlike fitting in, which requires you to hide or change parts of yourself to conform with external expectations, true belonging means you're accepted as you are.
- To achieve this, you must first embrace your authentic self and be willing to share it with others. Belonging is also reciprocal: it's not just about being accepted by others, but also about accepting those around you.



Connection is the energy we feel when we are seen, heard, and valued. It happens when we can be our true selves with others and receive care without judgment. This creates a sense of belonging, purpose, and support, helping us to cope with life's stresses.

- True connection is built on emotional availability, mutual trust and respect, allowing people to interact at a deeper level to feel understood and valued.



Disconnection occurs when we feel misunderstood, invalidated, or excluded. This causes both emotional pain and physical distress.

- It can occur when we're afraid to be vulnerable, leading to shallow or surface-level interactions. Digital interactions may also create distractions and hinder deep, in-person connections.
- When left unresolved, disconnection can create a sense of disempowerment, making us feel like we don't matter.



Insecurity arises from uncertainty about our self-worth, abilities, or relationships, making us feel vulnerable and anxious.

- There are 3 key types of insecurity:
 - (i) *Domain-specific* insecurity e.g. financial insecurity, food insecurity, or a lack of physical safety.

KEY QUOTES

"In the absence of love and belonging, there is always suffering."

"We have to belong to ourselves as much as we need to belong to others. Any belonging that asks us to betray ourselves is not true belonging."

"True belonging doesn't require us to change who we are; it requires us to be who we are."

"We become terrified of feeling pain, so we engage in behaviors that become a magnet for more pain."

(ii) *Relationship or interpersonal insecurity*: when we're unsure about being loved, valued, or protected in our relationships.

(iii) *General or personal insecurity*: being overly self-critical about our personal qualities or performance.

- The opposite of insecurity is self-security, which involves accepting your weaknesses without judgment.



Invisibility is the painful experience of being ignored, overlooked, or devalued in a relationship or social setting.

- There are different types of invisibility including: interpersonal invisibility (in relationships), group invisibility (affecting entire social groups), and representational invisibility (underrepresentation or negative portrayals in media and culture).
- Invisibility is a form of disconnection linked tied to stigma and stereotypes. It can leave people feeling stigmatized and unseen.



Loneliness is the feeling of isolation from others, often accompanied by a deep sadness or a longing for connection.

- Loneliness is not the same as being alone. The latter can be healing and restorative, while loneliness is painful due to the absence of meaningful social interaction. It can affect physical health, and is linked to higher risks of cardiovascular disease, dementia, and depression.
- To combat loneliness, we must recognize it and seek meaningful connections. To feel less isolated, reach out to a few people you trust and focus on quality over quantity in relationships.



10. Places We Go When the Heart Is Open



Love is a multifaceted emotion characterized by deep affection, attachment, and connection to others. It is central to human connection and emotional well-being.

- It is both an emotion and a set of actions that foster connection and trust. It can span from romantic love to familial love, platonic love, and self-love.

KEY QUOTES

"Self-security is the open and nonjudgmental acceptance of one's own weaknesses."

—Alice Huang and Howard Berenbaum

"Given that we are all here to be seen, known, and loved, invisibility is one of the most painful human experiences."

"Invisibility is its own form of stigmatization."

"We feel shame around being lonely—as if feeling lonely means there's something wrong with us. We feel shame even when our loneliness is caused by grief, loss, or heartbreak."

"Love is not something we give or get; it is something that we nurture and grow, a connection that can be cultivated between two people only when it exists within each one of them—we can love others only as much as we love ourselves."

- True love is rooted in mutual respect, trust, and compassion, not romantic or idealized notions. To build and maintain love, you need daily commitment, mutual respect, and care. Love also requires vulnerability and a willingness to embrace uncertainty.



Lovelessness is the emotional void left by the absence of love, trust, or connection in one's life. It can be caused by a lack of self-compassion or external experiences where trust has been broken.

- To recover from lovelessness, we must rebuild trust and develop the courage to be vulnerable again.



Heartbreak is the intense emotional pain that comes from losing someone or something we deeply care about.

- Heartbreak can come from the loss of love (through a breakup, death, or betrayal), the end of important relationships, unrequited love, or the failure of significant dreams and aspirations. It affects us physically and emotionally, often leading to feelings of grief, longing, and despair.
- It takes courage to love, since loving means the risk of heartbreak. To recover from heartbreak, you must allow yourself to grieve, seek support from others, and gradually open up to new connections or possibilities.



Trust is the belief that someone is reliable, honest, and has your best interests at heart. It's built gradually over time, through consistent actions that demonstrate integrity and care.

- Trust is the foundation of meaningful relationships. It involves the willingness to be vulnerable and the belief that others will act in our best interests and respect our boundaries.
- Here are the elements of trust using Brown's BRAVING acronym:
 - (i) Boundaries: Setting and respecting boundaries.
 - (ii) Reliability: Consistently doing what you say you will do.
 - (iii) Accountability: Owning your mistakes and making amends.
 - (iv) Vault: Holding what others share with you in confidence.
 - (v) Integrity: Practicing your values (not just professing them).

KEY QUOTES

"We need more real love. Gritty, dangerous, wild-eyed, justice-seeking love."

*"Heartbreak is what happens when love is lost."
—Joe Reynolds*

"The brokenhearted are the bravest among us—they dared to love."

"Heartbreak is unavoidable unless we choose not to love at all. A lot of people do just that."

"If someone says 'I don't trust you,' it feels like a general assault on our character."

(vi) Non-judgment: Asking for what you need without fear of judgment, and offering the same in return.

(vii) Generosity: Interpreting others' words/actions generously.

- Before cultivating trust with others, you must develop self-trust—confidence in your own abilities, judgments, and instincts, and knowing you'll act in alignment with your values.



Betrayal occurs when someone violates your trust by acting in a way that is disloyal, dishonest, or harmful. It shatters the trust and connection in a relationship, leading to feelings of hurt, anger, and disbelief. The deeper the trust, the more devastating the betrayal.

- Betrayal can take many forms, from infidelity in romantic relationships, to broken promises in friendships or professional settings, to institutional betrayal and self-betrayal.
- Betrayal can create deep and long-lasting emotional scars. It often leads to the loss of trust not only in the person who betrayed you, but in relationships in general. It can also impact self-esteem and mental health.
- To heal from betrayal, you need time to acknowledge the hurt, process your emotions, set boundaries and rebuild trust from the ground up.



Defensiveness is the instinctive reaction to protect ourselves from perceived threats or attacks to our self-esteem or self-worth.

- We often respond by denying responsibility, deflecting blame, or justifying behavior. It can block constructive conversations and feedback, strain relationships, and hinder learning and growth.
- To overcome defensiveness, learn to recognize the signs of defensiveness (e.g. tensed body language or tunnel vision) and intentionally shift your stance. For example, relax clenched fists and uncross your arms, or say something like, "I'm feeling overwhelmed. Can we take a 10-minute break and start over?"



Flooding is the sensation of overwhelm that occurs during high-conflict or emotionally-intense situations. We feel overloaded

KEY QUOTES

"Self-trust is normally the first casualty of failure or mistakes. We stop trusting ourselves when we hurt others, get hurt, feel shame, or question our worth."

"Betrayal is so painful because, at its core, it is a violation of trust."

"[Betrayal] happens in relationships in which trust is expected and assumed, so when it's violated, we're often shocked, and we can struggle to believe what's happening. It can feel as if the ground beneath us has given way."

"At its core, defensiveness is a way to protect our ego and a fragile self-esteem."

"Defensiveness blocks us from hearing feedback and evaluating if we want to make meaningful changes in our thinking or behavior based on input from others."

psychologically and physically, making it hard to focus, think logically, or communicate effectively.

- When we're emotionally flooded, we might shut down or lash out, worsening the conflict and emotional upheaval.
- The best way to manage flooding is to take a break—step away from the situation to regain control over your emotions, then re-engage in a calmer state.



Hurt is a blend of sadness and feelings of being emotionally wounded. It often occurs when someone's actions or words cause us to feel devalued or rejected, and may coexist with other emotions like anger, anxiety, jealousy, or loneliness.

- Hurt can range from mild disappointment to deep emotional pain. It's especially painful when the hurt is perceived as intentional. We might respond by blaming ourselves, retaliating, or seeking support/comfort.
- Hurt feelings shouldn't be confused with other emotional pain like grief or "feeling wounded." Brown recommends using the words "my feelings are hurt" to express yourself more clearly.



11. Places We Go When Life Is Good



Joy is an intense, momentary feeling of connection, pleasure, and appreciation. It's often linked with other people, nature, or a higher power. It expands our perspective, bringing a sense of freedom and presence that makes everything seem more vibrant.

- Research shows that joy and gratitude reinforce each other in an upward spiral. Experiencing joy increases future feelings of gratitude, which further enhances future moments of joy.



Happiness is a state of pleasure or contentment, often tied to external circumstances and experiences. It is more stable, less intense, and longer-lasting than joy.

- Happiness is associated with emotional well-being, but Brown cautions against an incessant pursuit of happiness as it can block deeper experiences of joy and gratitude.

KEY QUOTES

"There's only so much our bodies and nervous systems can stand before they flip the survival switch and stop communicating and start protecting or attacking."

"I'm not sure there's a braver sentence in the human catalog of brave sentences than 'My feelings are hurt.'"

"When we respond to hurt feelings with anger, the other person tends to match our anger with more anger."

"I love thinking of joy as 'the good mood of the soul.' There is definitely something soulful about joy."

"While experiencing joy, we don't lose ourselves, we become more truly ourselves."



Calm is a state of peace and mindfulness. It helps us to maintain perspective and manage emotional reactivity in stressful or chaotic situations. It involves (i) slowing down mentally and physically to focus mindfully on the present, and (ii) regulating our emotional reaction to respond thoughtfully (not impulsively).

- We can cultivate calm through practices like deep breathing and mindfulness. Whenever Brown feels herself getting anxious, she asks 2 quick questions to gain perspective and calm herself: "Do I have enough information to freak out?" and "Will freaking out help?" The answer is almost always "no" to both questions.



Contentment is the feeling of satisfaction, completeness, and "enoughness." It comes from accepting and appreciating what you have, so you don't feel the urge to keep seeking more, nor long for things to be different.

- Compared to joy and happiness, contentment is more subdued, steady, and internal. It is strongly correlated with better life satisfaction and well-being.
- You can cultivate contentment through gratitude practices, mindfulness, and focusing on what's within your control (e.g. joy in simplicity and personal growth).



Gratitude is a deep appreciation for the things, people, or experiences that bring meaning and connection to our lives. It involves (i) appreciating the value of what we have (e.g. material possessions, relationships, experiences) and (ii) actively celebrating those positive aspects of life instead of taking them for granted.

- Gratitude is linked to better well-being and emotional resilience, including improved sleep, creativity, decision-making skills, and lower blood pressure and aggression.
- It is both an emotion and a practice (or something we cultivate intentionally). Common gratitude practices include: journaling, meditations, and expressing what you're thankful for daily.



Foreboding Joy is the paradoxical experience of feeling joy while simultaneously fearing that it will be taken away.

- To protect ourselves from potential loss and pain, we mentally prepare for worst-case scenarios, marring the joyful moments in life. Learn to fully embrace the positive moments by leaning into joy and practicing gratitude.

KEY QUOTES

"Calm is an intention. Do we want to infect people with more anxiety, or heal ourselves and the people around us with calm?"

"Calm people...can bring perspective to complicated situations and experience their feelings without reacting to heightened emotions."

"Contentment is about satisfaction, and that, ironically, is an unsatisfying idea for a lot of people."

"Gratitude is a practice that can enrich our lives in meaningful ways."

"While gratitude is an emotion, if we want to experience its full power, we must also make it a practice."

"When we push away joy, we squander the goodness that we need to build resilience, strength, and courage."



Relief is the release of physical and emotional tension after a period of worry or fear.

- Relief brings a sense of safety and calm, allowing us to return to a more balanced emotional state. It's often accompanied by a deep sigh or exhale, which reduces muscle tension and signals the end of the stressful period, further enhancing the feeling of relief.



Tranquility is a state of calm, peace and relaxation associated with the absence of demand/pressure. It offers respite from daily pressures, allowing us to reconnect with ourselves and find inner peace/balance.

- Unlike contentment, which involves a sense of satisfaction, tranquility is characterized by the enjoyment of doing nothing. It usually involves:
 - (i) Being free from the pressures and demands of life; and
 - (ii) Being in a natural, restorative environment like forests, fields, or large bodies of water.



12. Places We Go When We Feel Wronged



Anger is an intense emotion when we feel wronged, disrespected, or treated unfairly. We believe someone else is responsible for an injustice, and that something can be done to right the wrong. Anger can range from mild irritation to full-blown rage.

- It compels us to act, making it a powerful catalyst for action and change. However, prolonged or unchecked anger can hurt relationships and lead to exhaustion.
- Often, anger masks deeper, more vulnerable emotions like hurt, fear, or grief. To manage anger, identify the root cause, then express it in a healthy, non-destructive way.



Contempt is a mix of anger and disgust, characterized by the feeling of moral superiority over another person or group. It involves a sense of disrespect or disdain, which can be dismissive or belittling.

KEY QUOTES

"Sighing serves as a type of reset button for our body. It not only signals relief to our body, but it enhances relief, and it reduces muscle tension."

"With contentment, we often have the sense of having completed something; with tranquility, we relish the feeling of doing nothing."

"Anger is...an emotion that we need to transform into something life-giving: courage, love, change, compassion, justice."

"Anger is a powerful catalyst but a life-sucking companion."

"When someone is angry at you, you've still got traction with them, but when they display contempt, you've been dismissed."
— Pamela Meyer

KEY QUOTES

"[It] is not that we need to disagree less, but we need to learn how to disagree better—without contempt or cruelty."

"With contempt, we look down on the other person and we want to exclude or ignore them. With disgust... we want to avoid being 'poisoned' (either literally or figuratively)."

"The language we use to dehumanize is effective because it actually taps into 'core disgust'... We reduce people into the things that make us grossed out."

"Language matters. It's the raw material of story, it changes how we feel about ourselves and others, and it's a portal to connection."

"Hate crime victims... have been targeted, beaten, and killed, not because of anything they've done, but because of who they are."

"[I believe] that people are harder to hate close up, and easier to hate when we're behind our ideological bunker and they're behind theirs."

- To manage contempt, start by recognizing it and figuring out why it exists. It often stems from unresolved issues like emotional pain or a desire to feel superior. Recognize the humanity in others to rebuild mutual respect, and reframe conflict as an opportunity for mutual understanding.



Disgust is a strong urge to distance ourselves from something we perceive as offensive, revolting, toxic, or harmful.

- It originally evolved to protect us from physical contamination like vomit or rotten food. However, it can also be directed towards behaviors, individuals, or ideas. The reaction is visceral and immediate, and can be dehumanizing.
- To manage disgust, learn to recognize when it's truly useful for safety, or merely judgmental or exclusionary.



Dehumanization is about seeing others as less than human.

- It often spreads through the use of degrading language and imagery, such as portraying certain groups/people as "rats," "cockroaches," or "savages." This creates an us-vs-them division, presenting the other party as our enemy, or something inhuman, immoral or dangerous. This makes it easier to justify acts of hatred, cruelty, and violence.
- To combat dehumanization, we must recognize the shared humanity of all people, even those we're in conflict with. Take personal accountability to stop the use of language and imagery that dehumanize others.



Hate is a powerful, destructive emotion, driven by a mix of feelings like repulsion, disgust, anger, fear, and contempt.

- It occurs when we believe a person or group is intentionally malicious or immoral, and that they're unlikely to change. This creates a strong desire to eliminate them mentally, socially, or physically, and leads to harmful actions like violence or emotional abuse. Hate crimes target victims for who they are, not what they have done.
- Hate is often spread by leaders who use stories/rhetoric to present the opposing party as a common enemy. Distance and a lack of direct contact can intensify hatred, making it easier for us to dehumanize and vilify others.

- It is much harder to hate someone when you see their humanity and understand their experiences. So, we can mitigate hate through critical thinking and empathy for others' points of view.



Self-Righteousness is the conviction that we are morally superior to others. People who exhibit self-righteousness tend to be judgmental and close-minded. They adopt a black-and-white view of morality and dismiss differing opinions as morally or intellectually inferior.

- Self-righteousness is about using moral outrage as a way to elevate oneself. It often masks personal insecurities or flaws, trapping people in a cycle of judgment and defensiveness. This is different from righteousness, where someone reacts appropriately to real injustice and seeks to do the right thing.
- To overcome self-righteousness, acknowledge that there are multiple perspectives, and others' views may be valid even when they differ from yours.



13. Places We Go to Self-Assess



Pride is a feeling of satisfaction and pleasure derived from our achievements or efforts. We can feel proud for ourselves and for others, e.g. pride in a loved one's accomplishments or a collective effort.

- Pride can be good or bad depending on the context:
 - (i) Healthy pride reflects true accomplishments based on real effort and mastery, and this can be a source of motivation and self-esteem.
 - (ii) However, pride can lead to arrogance or a sense of superiority if it becomes excessive or inflated. This form of pride alienates people and block growth or connection.



Hubris is an exaggerated sense of pride or self-confidence that is not rooted in genuine achievements or competence.

- It's associated with an inflated view of one's abilities, driven by narcissism, insecurity and the need for dominance. The outward show of confidence is often used to hide feelings of shame

KEY QUOTES

*"The self-righteous scream judgments against others to hide the noise of skeletons dancing in their own closets."
— John Mark Green*

"Moral outrage is selfenhancing and related to selfrighteous anger."

"Context and story are necessary to figure out what's driving...behaviors."

"Pride can be good for us, hubris is dangerous, and humility is key to grounded confidence and healthy relationships."

and insecurity, and dominance is used to make the person feel good.

- Hubris blinds us to our flaws/limitations, making it hard to learn from mistakes or feedback. It's dangerous as it can lead to conflict and poor decisions.
- To manage hubris, counterbalance it with humility: recognize our limitations, be open to feedback, and value others' contributions.

 **Humility** is an openness to new learning, grounded in an honest understanding of your strengths and weaknesses.

- It is not about meekness, self-doubt, or downplaying our achievements. It's a balanced and powerful trait that allows for growth and connect without arrogance. People who practice humility are more willing to admit mistakes, respect others' perspectives and experiences, and adjust their beliefs/behaviors in face of new information.



Putting It Together: Cultivating Meaningful Connections

 The 87 emotions and experiences above help us define what it means to be human. However, to build meaningful connections, we must apply this knowledge in our daily interactions.

 Brown's research showed that emotional barriers to connection are not always obvious. She calls these "near vs far enemies."

- "Near enemies" are emotional responses that seem constructive, but actually block connection. For example, pity might seem like empathy, but it lacks the emotional closeness and shared perspective required for true understanding.
- "Far enemies" are easier to identify since they are the direct opposites of positive traits (e.g. hatred is a far enemy of love). However, they can still pose challenges in real life.

 We can use our emotional vocabulary both as a tool to understand ourselves, and as a guide to deepen our relationships. To cultivate meaningful relationships, we must practice 3 sets of essential skills to transform emotional awareness into authentic connections.

KEY QUOTES

"To those of us observing hubris, it looks and feels terrible. However, to the person experiencing hubris, it feels good."

"I define narcissism as the shame-based fear of being ordinary."

"Humility is quieter but more genuine and ultimately more powerful than hubris."

"We become what we do—even when those things are outside of who we want to be."

"On the surface, the near enemies of emotions or experiences might look and even feel like connection, but ultimately they drive us to be disconnected from ourselves and from each other."

"Knowing and applying the language of human experience and emotion is a key property of all of the major categories that support meaningful connection."

- Grounded confidence: Knowing and embracing our true selves;
- Courage to walk alongside others: Being present to their joy and pain without judgment; and
- Story stewardship: Listen deeply and honoring others' stories and experiences with trust and care.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Understanding, labeling, and expressing our emotions effectively are key to improving clarity, deepening connections, and fostering personal growth. This book offers a detailed breakdown of the 87 emotions and experiences summarized above, along with personal anecdotes, research-backed insights, illustrations, examples and practical tips for navigating emotions in everyday life. For more details, please visit <https://brenebrown.com/>.



About the Author

Dr. Brené Brown, Ph.D., (born 1965) is an American research professor, author, and podcast host. She is a research professor at the University of Houston Graduate College of Social Work and previously served as a visiting professor at McCombs School of Business, University of Texas at Austin.



Renowned for her groundbreaking research on courage, vulnerability, shame, and empathy, Dr. Brown has delivered multiple TED Talks and lectures, and won numerous teaching awards. She also hosts two popular podcasts "Unlocking Us" and "Dare to Lead" where she explores these topics.

"If we want to find the way back to ourselves and one another, we need language and the grounded confidence to both tell our stories and to be stewards of the stories that we hear. This is the framework for meaningful connection."